

- It monitors host resources comprising most network operating systems, including Microsoft Windows.
- The NagVis plugin comes with an interactive editor.

The cons

- Text configuration isn't a good idea. You must stick to the Web interface. However, there too, some views aren't very logical.
- Third party or, rather, unofficial releases of the available plug-ins are poorly programmed and are without proper documentation. You must either use official releases or program plug-ins of your own.
- Nagios Remote Plugin Executor (NRPE) can do checks on remote servers, but causes a lot of load on the server.
- It provides alerts for each notification. But if you want to test on all 30 languages supported by your server, your inbox will be flooded with alerts.

Zabbix

Developed by Zabbix SIA and written in C, PHP and Java, Zabbix is an enterprise-class open source network monitoring tool created by Alexei Vladishev.

If you are on Linux, or more specifically, a Debian-based distro, Zabbix will prove to be awesome. However, it needs tweaking in certain aspects to work well anywhere.

The pros

- It offers high performance with high capacity, and is capable of monitoring thousands of devices.
- Great Web interface with JMX, as well as Web monitoring with secure user authentication and flexible permissions.
- It sends useful notification messages such as 'Low Disk Space on /var on server2' along with SMS alerts—features that are highly configurable.
- Real-time charts.
- Collected data is stored in databases (MySQL, PostgreSQL, SQLite, Oracle, IBM DB2).
- Client software for Linux, Solaris, HP-UX, AIX, FreeBSD, OpenBSD and various versions of Windows such as XP, Vista 7, Server 2008 and more.
- Paid support and paid custom programming available, along with great documentation and downloadable PDFs with screenshots.

The cons

- It takes a little more time to understand its concepts compared to other tools.
- The feature-rich Web interface may seem to be complex and confusing for casual users.
- The map editor may seem to be virtually unusable. Though it improves with use, it still lacks some basic features like adding values to the folder.
- Zabbix is painful when you need to monitor things. Templates are pretty useless here, particularly when

displaying pretty similar aspects, and are not as clear as they should be.

- Can only return one value per item. While Nagios returns OK/WARNING/ALERT and a text string, Zabbix doesn't. It has different items.
- Difficult to debug.

Zenoss

Developed and maintained by Zenoss Inc, according to Wikipedia, "Zenoss is a free and open source application, server, and network management platform based on the Zope application server." Its development started in 2002, and since then it has grown to become one of the leading network monitoring tools.

The pros

- Like all other network monitoring tools, Zenoss has a Web interface too. But what Zenoss offers is quite different—a beautiful interface, which is much easier to understand and quite interactive.
- Integration of Google Maps to show your servers worldwide.
- Works well with great reliability on SNMP, SSH and WMI (Windows Management Instrumentation).
- Offers time-series performance monitoring of devices and event management tools to annotate alerts.
- Has extended Microsoft Windows monitoring via WMI.
- Supports the Nagios plug-in format.

The cons

- Limited features available in the open source version. Full version needs to be paid for.
- Though the Web interface is amazing, it's quite slow compared to others, probably because Zope is bloated.
- You cannot figure out what's working. You can, however, add monitors and checks later to find out.
- Awkward configurability.

Though Nagios, Zabbix and Zenoss have some negative aspects, it's the users who must decide what best fits their needs. Zabbix does suit Linux extremely well, but ultimately, you should go for what fulfils your needs better. 

References

- [1] <http://en.wikipedia.org>
- [2] <http://dennisarslan.nl>

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